Document Five

The Line · 21st November, 1914

Dear Grandfather,

I have seen the trench now, and I do not think any description I attempt will do it justice, so I will simply tell you what is true and let you make of it what you will.

It is a ditch. That is the plain fact beneath all the maps and the terminology · a ditch, cut zig-zag into wet earth, with duckboards laid along the bottom that do not so much keep a man out of the mud as slow down how quickly he sinks into it. The smell is the thing no one warns you of. Not any single terrible smell, but a great many ordinary ones · latrines, wet wool, old food, unwashed men, something underneath it all I have decided not to examine too closely · combined into something that simply becomes the air you breathe, until you stop noticing it and only notice, with something like alarm, when for a moment you don't.

There are rats the size of cats, genuinely, Grandfather, I am not exaggerating for effect · bold, unbothered creatures who have clearly concluded the war was arranged for their benefit. There is a peculiar routine to it all: stand-to before dawn, stand-down after, the passing of rum, the cleaning of rifles, letters written by candle-stub, a hundred small ceremonies performed because performing them is the only thing standing between a man and simply staring at the wall of mud in front of him until he goes mad.

I must tell you about Private Hollis, because I find I cannot write this letter honestly without him in it, and because I believe I owe him that much.

He had been with us three days. He was from Sheffield, a clerk before the war, forty-one years old and rather proud of being the oldest man in the platoon, always making some joke about it. Yesterday morning, during stand-down, he raised his head above the parapet · I still do not know exactly why, whether to look at something or simply because three days of keeping it down had worn through his caution · and that was the whole of it. No barrage, no assault, no drama a newspaper could make anything of. A single shot, from somewhere we never located, and he was gone before anyone could reach him.

I keep turning it over, Grandfather. All this training, all this preparation, and a man can die because he lifted his head one inch too many, on an ordinary Tuesday, for no reason anyone will ever be able to give his wife.